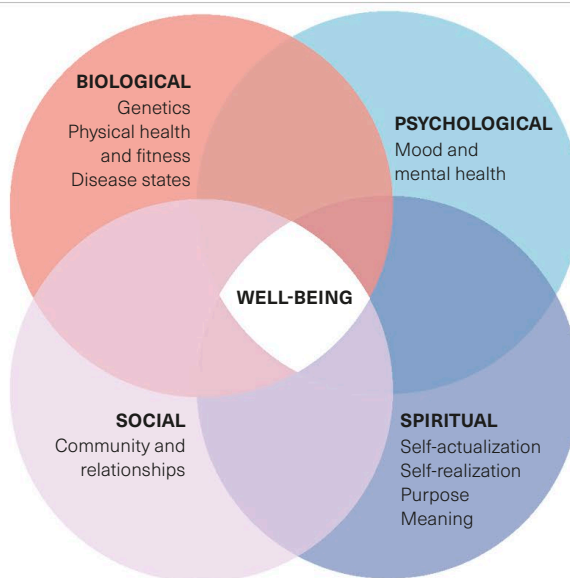


Q HOW DOES YOGA THERAPY WORK?

Yoga has profound therapeutic potential because it acts on what researchers call a biopsychosocial-spiritual model (see right). Much of yoga research is done through this lens, showing therapeutic yoga's promise for multidimensional conditions such as chronic pain, trauma, and anxiety. Just as with the koshas (see left), the core of yoga therapy is that each aspect of self interacts with the others. To address this, yoga therapy applies a balance of research evidence, client values, and clinician experience.



BIOPSYCHOSOCIAL-SPIRITUAL MODEL

Q DO WE HAVE SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE TO SUPPORT THE BENEFITS OF YOGA THERAPY?

Yes. The vast majority of scientific research into yoga is focused on understanding its therapeutic benefits, particularly for one of the world's most pressing healthcare issues: lifestyle-based chronic diseases (see pp.178–79, pp.188–91, and pp.194–95). The quality of this research is also improving, although some of the therapeutic benefits of yoga may never be fully understood through Western scientific inquiry. The yoga therapy profession is now growing partly because of the need for highly trained individuals who can work with specialized populations, for example veterans and those in cancer care.

Q HOW DOES YOGA THERAPY COMPARE TO OTHER HEALTHCARE PRACTICES?

Most healthcare systems work on the level of pathogenesis, which is a disease-based model of healthcare. The primary aim in this model is managing symptoms and “fixing” parts and pieces of the system. Although yoga therapy often is successful at managing symptoms, such as by providing pain relief, it also works on a level of salutogenesis, which is a health-based model. Rather than focusing on the disease to be cured or a problem to be fixed, salutogenesis focuses on creating well-being. Lifestyle changes and mindset shifts from yoga, therefore, can help people move beyond a disease focus to cultivate human flourishing.